

THE ENERGY OF OTHERS

witchcraft in the Internet age

The rise of the Internet has played a significant role in the expansion of witchcraft during the 21st century. A sharp increase in the number of dedicated websites, blogs, and social media sites has helped the movement to thrive by enabling practitioners to access like-minded souls in virtual covens. As a means of promoting feelings of personal empowerment—one of the core aims of modern witchcraft—the online world has proved a great boon.



◀ Past and future

Social media meets folklore, as a traditionally dressed Romanian witch takes a selfie before beginning a live ritual on Facebook in April 2019.

always faith-based—gods and goddesses feature according to the individual's preference. Often the emphasis of modern witchcraft is placed on the release of liberating and healing powers, and on finding a way to connect these transformative energies with the natural world.

Transformative energies

Clear differences between “technopagans” and the older, more established practitioners of Wicca (see pp.264–267) have been reinforced by the use of the Internet. The calling of this new generation is not

Another consequence of an Internet-linked society is that it has led to the embrace of political activism as a legitimate goal of witchcraft. Magic and activism have become linked through an online network of communities, which stress the importance of witchcraft as a means of creating a more just and equitable world.

As the scope of witchcraft in the 21st century has expanded with the Internet, so has its commercial prospects. Online selling of items such as crystals, potions (and recipes), tarot cards, and Ouija boards taps into witchcraft as a fashion and lifestyle statement. In Romania, the *vrajitoare* (witches) offer online consultations for a fee: services include fortune-telling and boosting romantic hopes.

IN PRACTICE

Emoji spells

Not all 21st-century witchcraft takes itself seriously, as is suggested by the growth of emoji spells. The practitioner uses their mobile phone like a magic wand to conjure and send nonverbal spells to themselves or others. Emoji spell-makers draw on folk traditions, for example, first creating a magic circle for protection (afterward cast aside) and breathing deeply to induce a sense of serenity. Thereafter almost anything can be wished for, from a better cup of coffee to less time spent waiting at airport security.



Crystal balls flank DIY and dollar signs in a wealth spell.



“I see pagans, especially witches, as evolving into what I will call the People of the Web.”

M. MACHA NIGHTMARE, PRIESTESS AND WITCH, 2009